

Buyer Self-Serve (Phase 24) — Paid-Tier Models & Content Protection

Competitive research and strategic analysis for the business-model decision

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1. The reframe that matters most

Funūn is not the same business as its competitors — and that dictates the tier.

Nearly every competitor wins with **subscription-as-license**: pay a fee, download unlimited, and the subscription *is* the license. They can do that because they **own or flat-rate-license their whole catalog**. Funūn **does not**. Funūn *represents* independent artists at **per-deal pricing** — the artist blanket-pre-authorizes terms *except price*, which is set per placement. So Funūn cannot offer “subscription = license the whole catalog” without artists opting into flat-rate pricing — which is exactly the unresolved **sync-license signing model** and **Phase 29**.

The consequence: the market-winning paid tier is **coupled to the signing decision**. The version buildable *without* it is a weaker “paid access / preview membership.” **That tension is the Phase 24 decision.**

2. The competitive landscape (mid-2026)

Three archetypes describe the whole market. Only the third — agency / per-deal — matches how Funūn is actually structured today.

Platform	Model	Pricing (entry → commercial → business)	License validity	Tiered by
Epidemic Sound	Sub-as-license	~\$10 personal → ~\$17 commercial → ~\$30 business/mo	While subscribed (safelisting active)	Use
Artist	Sub-as-license	~\$16.58 music → \$39.99 bundle (music+video+AI)/mo	Perpetual — keep what you used forever	Content bundle
Soundstripe	Sub-as-license	~\$10 / \$20 / \$34 mo; ~\$999/yr business; single track \$49	Perpetual for licensed use	Use
Uppbeat	Freemium	Free (attribution + caps) → ~\$7.99/mo removes friction	While subscribed	Free vs paid
Audiio	Subscription + lifetime	\$199/yr, or ~\$299 one-time lifetime (music)	Perpetual (lifetime option)	Term
Marmoset	Agency / per-deal	Negotiated per placement (scope × media × reach); + Track Club sub	Per license	Per deal

Platform	Model	Pricing (entry → commercial → business)	License validity	Tiered by
Musicbed	Hybrid	Unlimited sub \$30–100/mo by category; single track \$59+	While subscribed / per license	Buyer category

The three archetypes, in words

- **Subscription-as-license** (Epidemic, Artist, Soundstripe): the sub *is* the license; unlimited downloads; requires flat-rate rights to the whole catalog. Validity is either while-subscribed (Epidemic) or perpetual for what you used during the term (Artist).
- **Freemium** (Uppbeat): free tier with attribution + download caps converts to a low-priced paid tier (~\$7.99/mo) that removes friction and adds channel whitelisting. Proves freemium converts.
- **Lifetime** (Audiio): a one-time payment (~\$299) for perpetual catalog access — rare, and a useful pricing lever.
- **Agency / per-deal** (Marmoset; Musicbed single-track): browse, then license *per placement*, custom-priced by scope × media × reach. **This is Funūn's native model.**
- **Hybrid** (Musicbed): an unlimited subscription *and* single-track licensing under one comparable structure — the likely long-term end state for a catalog that can support both.

3. Four options for Funūn's paid tier

- **Option A — Paid access / preview membership (NOT a license).** A “Pro buyer” subscription granting enhanced access: full-catalog browse, watermarked preview/comp downloads for consideration, saved shortlists, early access to new drops, priority AE response. Licensing still happens per deal. **Buildable now — decoupled from counsel.** Weaker value prop (buyers may balk at paying for access *and* per-deal licenses).
- **Option B — Subscription-as-license (Epidemic / Artist-style).** The market-winning model, but requires a curated sub-catalog where **artists opt into flat-rate / blanket-price licensing** → gated on the sync-license signing model, Phase 29, and artist supply. Bigger, later.
- **Option C — Freemium entry (Uppbeat-style).** Free browse + limited watermarked comps (friction) → paid removes friction, unlocks full preview and, if/when B exists, licensed downloads + whitelisting. Pairs with A or B.
- **Option D — Hybrid (Musicbed-style).** Paid membership + a Phase-29 flat-price self-serve lane for small deals, with AE-negotiated for premium/exclusive. The likely long-term end state — needs the signing model for the flat-price lane.

4. Content protection — corrected for a non-owner

Funūn must NOT register or administer YouTube Content ID directly.

The subscription libraries above register their catalog in Content ID because they **own or exclusively license** it. Funūn represents artists — it does not own the songs — so this is out of scope (already an explicit constraint in 16-CONTEXT: “Direct Content ID administration”).

Three reasons, all rooted in “you represent the songs, you don’t own them”:

- **Content ID requires verifiable ownership / exclusive rights** — Funūn has neither; the artists own their masters.
- **YouTube gates direct Content ID access** to large, owned-catalog rights holders and aggregators. A representative with a small, non-exclusive catalog doesn’t qualify and shouldn’t try.
- **The artists’ released music is usually already in Content ID** via their own distributor (DistroKid, TuneCore, etc.). Registering it again would double-claim — false-claiming the artists’ own uploads and their fans, and asserting rights Funūn doesn’t hold.

What Funūn does instead

- **Now — in-house, no ownership needed:** hand buyers only a **watermarked** preview (an audible tag to deter, plus an inaudible **forensic** watermark tied to the specific buyer so a leak traces back to them); release the **clean master only after the license is signed**; and stamp a **license-ID into the delivered file’s metadata** for provenance. Pure engineering, no vendor dependency.
- **Later — a partnership, not a build:** once deal volume justifies it, plug Funūn’s license database into a Content ID **aggregator** that already has access (AdRev/Symphonic, Pex/Vobile, Song Zu, Too Lost) so a *licensed* buyer’s upload auto-clears — with the artist/distributor’s authorization. Funūn never becomes the Content ID owner.

The wrinkle worth knowing

Because a released track is often *already* in the artist’s **distributor’s** Content ID, even a properly **licensed** buyer’s video can still get claimed by that distributor. So the per-deal license needs a **claim-clearance mechanism** — via the aggregator partner, or coordinated per deal with the artist/distributor. Another reason the whole thing leans on the sync-license signing / clearance model, which loops back to the decision that also gates 16-09, Phase 24, and Phase 29.

5. Is there ANY scenario where Funūn should hold its own Content ID?

Yes — exactly one. Tracks where Funūn has **exclusive** sync + Content-ID rights **and** that aren’t already registered in anyone else’s Content ID. In practice that means **unreleased / Funūn-exclusive Sound-Vault / Sync-Library catalog** — which is how production-music libraries operate.

Three conditions must all hold:

- the artist grants Funūn **exclusive Content-ID administration** for the track;
- **nothing else already claims it** — Content ID can’t have two owners of the same reference in a territory, or it’s a conflict;
- Funūn registers through an **aggregator** (AdRev/Symphonic, Pex/Vobile), **not** directly — YouTube won’t hand direct CMS access to a small representative.

For the **default** case — non-exclusive representation of tracks already distributed elsewhere — it stays a **no**. So this is really a **signing-model question**: does Sync Library inclusion grant Funūn *exclusive* rights

(Content ID becomes viable for that slice) or not?

6. Flagging unlicensed use — and what MusicBed's “ID” actually is

You're describing two different jobs — and MusicBed's ID only does one of them.

Detection (find unlicensed use) and **clearance** (release claims on *licensed* use) are separate systems. MusicBed's “ID” is clearance. What Funūn actually needs — detection — does *not* require owning Content ID.

MusicBed's “ID” = SyncID — that's clearance, not detection

MusicBed's system is **SyncID** (with a “**SyncID Key**” — a code the buyer drops in the video description or dispute box). It does **not** find unlicensed use. When YouTube's Content ID flags a video, SyncID checks **(linked channel) × (active subscription) × (license on file)** and **auto-releases the claim in seconds** for licensed users — often before the creator even sees the claim email — leaving *unlicensed* uses claimed. It works only because **MusicBed owns and registers its catalog in Content ID**: that registration is what does the detecting; SyncID just clears it for the people who paid. Funūn can replicate this only for the exclusive slice in Section 5, via an aggregator.

Detecting / flagging unlicensed use does NOT require owning Content ID

Use a third-party **audio-fingerprinting monitor** — **ACRCloud, Audible Magic, Gracenote, or Pex (now Vobile)** — which scan YouTube *plus dozens of social / UGC platforms* for your represented tracks' fingerprints with no ownership stake. The flow:

- Register Funūn's represented catalog as reference fingerprints with the monitor (artist-authorized).
- It reports every match across platforms.
- Funūn cross-references each match against its **license database** → anything with no Funūn license (and not the artist's own authorized use) is **flagged**.
- Follow up: takedown / outreach / convert-to-license — acting **on the artist's behalf** (you need that authorization in the agreement, since you don't own the right).
- For leaked *previews* specifically, the **forensic watermark** pinpoints the exact buyer who leaked it.

Net

Funūn's flagging layer = **fingerprint-monitoring service + license-DB cross-reference + forensic preview watermark** — none of which needs Funūn to own Content ID. A SyncID-style auto-clear is a separate, later, aggregator-partner job, only for the exclusive-catalog slice. Notably, **Pex/Vobile can do both** the detection *and* the aggregator/clearance side, so it could be a single partner.

7. The decision

The single question to lead the discussion

Would buyers pay for a tier that grants access / preview but still charges per-deal for licenses?

- **If no** → Phase 24 collapses into the same signing-model dependency as 16-09 and Phase 29. Resolve the sync-license signing model (with counsel) first; then Phase 24 = Option B or D.
- **If yes** → the **Option A membership is the one piece that can ship now**, independent of counsel, and it seeds the buyer base + the content-protection plumbing (watermark, license-DB, monitoring) that B and D will reuse.

Dependency map

Sync-license signing model (music/IP counsel) is the keystone — resolving it unblocks **16-09** (buyer-side e-sign), the licensing half of **Phase 24** (Options B/D), and **Phase 29** (flat-price self-serve). The exclusive-vs-non-exclusive question inside it also decides whether the Section-5 Content-ID carve-out is ever available. Everything downstream of buyer self-serve is gated on that one decision.

8. Owner direction — hybrid, phased (2026-08-10)

The owner has chosen a **hybrid** model, built in two lanes as the catalogue grows. Both sit on the same **browsable catalogue = every song Funūn represents** (owned or not), shopped into sync deals against live client briefs.

Lane 1 — AE-negotiated per-deal (single-track) sync — NOW

Mid-size deals (~\$0–\$100K, and Funūn won't turn down bigger) with agencies, film/TV, and brands. Priced per placement (scope × media × reach); AEs run the negotiation and the deal room. **This lane works today** — it rides the existing artist blanket pre-authorization (terms agreed *except price*; price set per deal), so it is **not** blocked by the flat-rate signing question. This is the Phase 16 deal-room / license-request workflow.

Lane 2 — Subscription for small-audience buyers (Musicbed-style) — LATER

Influencers and small creators pay a monthly fee — **freemium** → **~\$100+/mo (tiering TBD)** — to license up to N songs/month, scaled by audience size. **This lane is signing-model-gated**: a subscriber licenses *without* a per-deal negotiation, which requires artists to **opt a subset of tracks into flat-rate / blanket-price licensing** (Phase 29 + the sync-license signing model + explicit artist opt-in). It **also requires the Content ID clearance layer** (Section 9) — subscription buyers post to YouTube at volume and can't dispute claims one by one.

Sequencing & coexistence

Lane 1 launches now. Lane 2 follows once its three prerequisites are met: (a) the **flat-rate artist opt-in** model (signing model / Phase 29); (b) the **Content ID aggregator clearance** partnership; (c) the **subscription design** (tiers, per-month song caps, audience-scaling, freemium→\$100+ pricing). The two then run side by side — bespoke/large = AE per-deal; standard/small = self-serve subscription. **Lane 1 is unblocked and can proceed now; Lane 2 is the signing-model-gated piece** and cannot launch until artists opt in to flat-rate terms *and* the clearance layer exists. This is Option D (hybrid) from Section 3.

9. Recommended content-protection architecture

Three layers over one spine — the **license database** (buyer × track × scope × term × status), which every layer reads.

- **1 · Distribution control — NOW, in-house (no ownership).** Every file a buyer receives is a **watermarked preview**: an audible tag to deter, plus an inaudible **forensic** watermark keyed to the buyer + deal so a leak traces to the exact recipient. The **clean master is released only on an executed license**, and every delivered file carries a **Funūn license-ID in its metadata** (ID3/BWF) for provenance.
- **2 · Detection / monitoring — NOW→NEAR, partner API (no ownership).** Register represented tracks (artist-authorized) as reference fingerprints with a monitor — **Pex/Vobile, ACRCLOUD, or Audible Magic**. Ingest match reports across YouTube + social/UGC, **cross-reference against the license DB**, and flag any use with no matching Funūn license (and not the artist's own) into a triage queue → takedown / outreach / convert-to-license, on the artist's behalf per the agreement.
- **3 · Clearance — LATER, aggregator partnership (required for Lane 2).** Plug the license DB into a Content ID **aggregator** (AdRev/Symphonic, Pex/Vobile, Song Zu...) so a **licensed** buyer's YouTube upload **auto-clears** (Musicbed SyncID-equivalent), with artist/distributor authorization. Funūn never becomes the Content ID owner. **Carve-out:** for the **exclusive / unreleased** subset (Section 5), Funūn may hold the reference directly via the aggregator.

Phasing tied to the lanes

Lane 1 (AE per-deal) needs layers 1–2 + **per-deal manual clearance** (fine for occasional large placements). **Lane 2 (subscription) additionally requires layer 3** — at influencer volume, auto-clear is not optional, so the aggregator clearance is a **launch prerequisite for Lane 2, not Lane 1. Never:** Funūn-owned Content ID for the general (non-exclusive) catalogue — that stays the artists' distributors' job.

Sources (accessed 2026-08-10)

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- Musicbed — new pricing (musicbed.com); SyncID (musicbed.com/articles/resources/youtube-content-id-claims)
- Soundstripe — pricing (photutorial.com/soundstripe-pricing)
- Marmoset — music licensing + Track Club (marmosetmusic.com)
- Uppbeat — pricing (upbeat.io/pricing); Audiio — lifetime (audiio.com/lifetime-music-licensing)
- Detection — ACRCLOUD, Audible Magic, Gracenote, Pex/Vobile (acrcloud.com; techcrunch.com ACRCLOUD profile)
- Internal: `.planning/phases/24-buyer-onboarding-self-serve/24-RESEARCH-paid-tiers.md`; `16-CONTEXT.md`; `.planning/research/COMPETITOR-musicbed-buyer-experience.md`